



# Story elements, narrative transportation, and schema incongruity: a framework for enhancing brand storytelling effectiveness

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## ABSTRACT

Storytelling is a powerful tool used by brand marketers. However, most brand stories are neither memorable nor effective. This research proposes a model for increasing the effectiveness of brand storytelling through the use of incongruity. Incongruity can challenge the expectations of brand storytelling held in the minds of consumers (i.e., the brand story schema). This increases attentional focus on the story and triggers more complex cognitive processing. This level of processing is necessary for effective narrative transportation, or immersion into the story. This research identifies the key elements of storytelling (e.g., character, setting, and plot) and demonstrates how marketers can introduce incongruity through these elements. Moderating factors and brand outcomes are introduced to improve implementation and foster strategy development.

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## Introduction

Brand storytelling has become a focus of marketers in recent years, and with good reason. In a survey of 2,000 adults by marketing agency Headstream, 79% indicated that they want brands to tell stories in their marketing, but 85% could not give an example of a memorable brand story they had seen (Mortimer, 2015). Consumers are now awash in branded ‘clutter’ found in online ads, videos, blogs, and other outlets; all of it demanding attention, but much of it lacking in added value. A recent study from media agency Havas found that 84% of consumers expect brands to produce content such as videos, podcasts, or experiential events (Vizard, 2017). Yet, the same study found that 60% of consumers rate this content as poor quality or irrelevant.

Consumers prefer narratives over factual arguments (e.g., Adaval & Wyer, Jr., 1998; Escalas, 2007; Polyorat et al., 2007), but marketers struggle with creating stories that are both engaging and effective at driving business outcomes. Brand storytellers must find new ways to gain the attention of consumers and make an impression. One effective way to grab attention is to use incongruent elements in the story that counter expectations, which research does not adequately explore.

The expectations we have for stories derive from schemas, or semantic knowledge structures, encoded and stored in our memory over time as we experience storytelling (DeRosia et al., 2011; Mandler, 1982; Sujan & Bettman, 1989). When a new story is encountered, schemas are accessed. Comparisons and judgments are made, attitudes are formed, and new schemas are encoded in relation to what was already known. A similar process occurs in branding with brand schemas, which hold our knowledge and expectations for brands (Arbouw et al., 2019; Bhaduri & Ha-Brookshire, 2017; Halkias, 2015).

Brand storytellers must be aware of story-related schemas held in consumers' minds if they are to tell effective stories. This is true if they want their stories to follow conventional norms and meet expectations, or if they wish to surprise the consumer by defying storytelling norms (e.g., Phillips & McQuarrie, 2010). Straightforward stories that align with consumer expectations can certainly be effective. But in the fight over consumer attention that is happening today, these stories risk appearing bland and predictable. If marketers wish to defy expectations and become unpredictable, they must introduce elements to the story that are incongruent with the schemas held in consumers' minds. Incongruity creates tension, which leads to more complex and deliberate processing in the minds of consumers (Lee & Schumann, 2004). More complex processing can lead to narrative transportation (Green & Brock, 2000), which produces more impactful storytelling (Van Laer et al., 2013).

The objective of this research is to propose a new way to conceptualize brand storytelling and improve effectiveness by introducing elements of incongruity. But before a marketer can break storytelling norms and defy expectations, it is important to first understand these norms. Stories are usually structured chronologically, with a beginning, middle, and end (Escalas, 2004). Stories have elements that can be identified, such as characters, setting, plot, theme, conflict, and resolution. We expect these elements to take familiar shape, or fit a predetermined structure, depending on the type of story being told (Heckler & Childers, 1992; Maille & Fleck, 2011). Storytellers manipulate these elements to achieve different effects. In the case of brand storytelling, marketers are able to strategically manipulate these elements to achieve brand outcomes such as a change in attitudes or beliefs.

Storytelling is a way to convey meaningful ideas, and it can act 'as a clear aid to memory, as a means of making sense of the world, as a way to make and strengthen emotional connections, and as way of recognizing and identifying with brands of any type' (Herskovitz & Crystal, 2010, p. 21). People naturally think in terms of narratives rather than arguments, and in that sense the human brain may be hard-wired for narratives (Jameson, 1981; Schank, 1990; Schank & Abelson, 1995; Turner, 1998). Storytelling has a natural place in marketing, as the human impulse to seek out narratives and symbols that help form identity may be core to the idea of branding (Hirschman, 2010). Accordingly, storytelling can drive positive attitudes toward the brand (Coker et al., 2017), foster feelings of trust with clients and decision makers (Anaza et al., 2020; Gilliam & Flaherty, 2015) and create an enhanced customer-brand experience (Lemon & Verhoef, 2016; Lundqvist et al., 2013).

Despite the importance of storytelling and the benefits of countering expectations, little research exists on either the strategic manipulation of story elements or the use of incongruity in brand storytelling. These gaps in knowledge leave marketers guessing as

to why their brand stories sometimes fail to connect with consumers. Managers have little guidance for how to adjust the storytelling process to improve marketing outcomes. For storytelling research to have managerial relevance, these gaps need to be addressed. Thus, this research seeks to answer the following research questions:

RQ1: What effect do incongruent story elements have on narrative processing?

RQ2: Could incongruity positively impact storytelling outcomes related to the brand?

RQ3: How do situational or message factors impact the effectiveness of storytelling incongruity?

This research proposes a model for enhancing storytelling effectiveness with the strategic and specific use of incongruity to enhance the likelihood of narrative transportation. First, the storytelling process and the role of schema incongruity in brand storytelling are discussed. A conceptual model is proposed, including moderating factors that could dampen or enhance the effectiveness of brand storytelling. Guidelines are offered for manipulating specific story elements to achieve incongruity. Examples of brand stories using incongruence are provided to further aid implementation. Ideas for future research in this space are also proposed.

## Schema incongruity and storytelling mechanics

A *schema* is a semantic knowledge structure that allows us to make sense of new information and experiences in the world based on what we have already learned and experienced (Anderson, 1988; Beals, 1998; Yoon, 2013). When a new experience occurs, schemas related to that experience are triggered. The new input is compared to these schemas and encoded to memory in relation to what is known (Beals, 1998).

When new information about an object (i.e., a brand, product, or ad) can be easily categorized by existing schemas, it is *schema congruent* information (e.g., a Tesla ad touting the benefits of electric cars). In contrast, when new information does not easily relate to existing schemas, it is *schema incongruent* (e.g., a Tesla ad featuring a car flying in space). The level of incongruence is determined by the degree to which the new information conflicts with existing schema or expectations (Halkias & Kokkinaki, 2013, 2014; Meyers-Levy et al., 1994). Different levels of incongruity trigger different levels of processing in the mind (Mandler, 1982).

Information containing little or no incongruity does not require complex processing. Any incongruence would go unnoticed, and the message may not gain the attention of the receiver. In contrast, moderate levels of incongruity requires more complex processing in the receiver's mind. This processing triggers either an attempt to accommodate the new information with existing schema, or the development of an alternative schema to categorize the new information. Accommodation can be successful or unsuccessful, leading to different affective responses. Severe incongruity requires a high level of attention and complex processing and is unlikely to be understood by all receivers. The result is often unsuccessful accommodation of the new information and a negative reaction. In cases of severe incongruity, the highly incongruent elements can lack any

sense of relevancy. That is, the elements detract from, rather than contribute to, identification of the message in the story (Heckler & Childers, 1992; Maille & Fleck, 2011).

Empirical studies show that moderate levels of incongruence produce more favorable evaluations than either congruence or extreme incongruence (Meyers-Levy & Tybout, 1989). Halkias and Kokkinaki (2013, 2014) document the presence of an 'inverted U' relationship between the levels of ad-brand incongruity and positive outcomes such as recall and attitudes. Moderate incongruity is more likely to be accommodated successfully (Lee & Schumann, 2004; Mandler, 1982). This could result in either a positive or negative response, but the response is more likely to be based on the information presented and not an inability to process the incongruity. The lesson for marketers is clear: Too little incongruity can produce easily processed but unremarkable messages, while too much incongruity can confuse consumers and produce negative reactions. However, a moderate amount of incongruity can draw the attention of the consumer, trigger complex processing, and generate responses to the branded communication with little risk of the message being lost on the consumer.

Incongruity can take many forms, depending on the elements in question. Similarity or dissimilarity can occur between objects according to physical characteristics or imagery, the sensations or emotions elicited by the objects, the time and space in which the objects exist, the manner in which the objects are used, and more (Maille & Fleck, 2011). The storytelling process and story elements provide a multitude of objects and qualities that can be set apart from each other through dissimilarity to produce incongruity.

### ***Narrative transportation***

Complex processing is key to effective storytelling because of the mechanics of how storytelling works. *Narrative transportation*, or absorption into the story, is the process that separates stories from other forms of influential communication. Through narrative transportation, stories engage our senses and produce experiences similar to those in the real world (see Paul, 2012 for a review of the neurological research). Narrative transportation can generate vivid mental imagery and produce both affective and cognitive responses, leading to changes in beliefs, attitudes, intentions, and behavior (Dunlop et al., 2010; Kim et al., 2016; Van Laer et al., 2013). As a result, consumers identify with the characters in a story and attach meaning to the brands and products used (Cooper et al., 2010).

Transportation first requires attentional focus on the imagery and affect portrayed in a story, which incongruity can achieve. As discussed, attentional focus leads to complex processing, which is required for the receiver to be transported. The stronger the transportation effect, the more likely the receiver will form favorable evaluations and adopt story-consistent beliefs (Green & Brock, 2000). Narrative transportation can occur with narratives based on either fact or fiction, which is good news for marketers who frequently blend the two for brand storytelling. Transportation can also cause consumers to gloss over 'false notes' in the story that may ordinarily trigger disengagement and counter-arguing (Green & Brock, 2000).

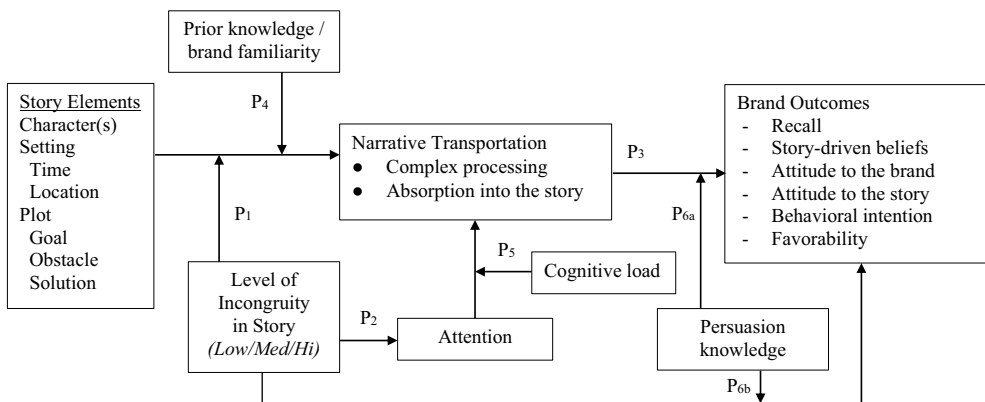
## Brand story schema

Prior marketing research assumes that consumers use only brand schemas to evaluate brand communications. Alternatively, consumers may use schema held for the storytelling medium itself to judge brand stories. Consumers have years of experience with stories. Just as they hold expectations (and schemas) for brands and products, they also hold expectations (and schemas) for the storytelling process. We expect stories to follow the familiar pattern of a linear, chronologically ordered narrative with a clear beginning, middle, and end (Escalas, 2004). Stories feature one or more characters, a setting, and a plot (i.e., goals, conflict, and resolution) (Lamb, 2008). The specific makeup and structure of these elements can vary based on the story genre, the writing style of the author, and other factors. For the purposes of this research, the following story elements are examined within brand storytelling: character, setting (time and location), and plot (goal, challenges, solution). Elements of a brand story encountered by consumers will either agree (be congruent) or disagree (be incongruent) with the schemas consumers hold for these elements.

## Conceptual model

This research proposes a model of brand storytelling that explains how brand story schema incongruity can impact narrative processing and ultimately brand outcomes (See Figure 1). Storytelling elements provide imagery and produce affect, two of the necessary inputs for narrative transportation (Green & Brock, 2000). Factors related to the message and the message source (i.e., brand) attenuate the likelihood that story elements will drive narrative transportation. Story elements can also impact attention, the third prerequisite for transportation. Individual and situational factors affect the likelihood that attention will activate narrative transportation. Brand outcomes will be impacted based on the effectiveness of narrative transportation.

The following section introduces the constructs featured in the conceptual model and propositions that detail how these constructs will relate to each other in the model.



**Figure 1.** Conceptual model of brand story incongruity and narrative transportation.

### ***Level of incongruity***

The level of incongruity between new story elements and the existing story schema will determine whether complex processing takes place in the mind of the receiver (Mandler, 1982). Low levels of incongruity do not trigger complex processing, which is necessary for narrative transportation. High levels of incongruity can prevent the receiver from accommodating the new information, preventing processing from taking place. In the cases of both high and low levels of incongruity, narrative transportation is unlikely. Moderate levels of incongruity lead to complex processing, and thus an increased likelihood of narrative transportation (e.g., Halkias & Kokkinaki, 2013, 2014). To account for the inverted U relationship, two related propositions are offered:

P<sub>1a</sub>: Low or high levels of incongruity in story elements will decrease the likelihood of narrative transportation.

P<sub>1b</sub>: Moderate levels of incongruity in story elements will increase the likelihood of narrative transportation.

While the level of incongruity can affect the likelihood that the story elements will trigger narrative transportation, incongruity also impacts attention level, which is a primary driver of narrative transportation. Increased levels of incongruity are more likely to gain the attention of viewers (Germelmann et al., 2020). But unlike the previous relationship, there is no evidence of an inverted U here. Thus:

P<sub>2a</sub>: Higher levels of incongruity in story elements will increase the amount of attention paid to the story and the likelihood that narrative transportation will occur.

P<sub>2b</sub>: Lower levels of incongruity in story elements will decrease the amount of attention paid to the story and the likelihood that narrative transportation will occur.

### ***Narrative transportation and brand outcomes***

Narrative transportation requires imagery and affect (delivered by the story) and the attentional focus of the receiver. This triggers complex processing that immerses the receiver in the story both cognitively and affectively, often producing vivid mental images (Green, 2004). Transportation can lead to the receiver disengaging from existing attitudes and beliefs and updating them based on what is conveyed in the story (Van Laer et al., 2013).

Through this process, narrative processing can create and enhance self-brand connections, helping to incorporate the brand into a consumer's self-concept and produce favorable attitudes (Escalas, 2004). Transported individuals are more likely to perform story-consistent behaviors such as buying a product or taking better care of themselves (Van Laer et al., 2013). Additionally, there is evidence that both narrative transportation and schema incongruity can lead to better recall of a message (Shen & Chen, 2006; Van Laer et al., 2013). Thus:

P<sub>3</sub>: Narrative transportation will lead to:

- (1) better brand recall,
- (2) increased likelihood of adopting story-driven beliefs,

- (3) positive attitude to the brand,
- (4) positive attitude to the story,
- (5) behavioral intentions in line with the message, and
- (6) increased favorability of the brand.

## ***Moderating factors***

### ***Prior knowledge/brand familiarity***

Familiarity that comes from having prior knowledge or personal experience with a story topic increases the likelihood of narrative transportation (Van Laer et al., 2013). An individual's familiarity with the brand may also help incongruent elements stand out, requiring complex processing. Evidence suggests that the use of incongruity may be more worthwhile for familiar (vs. unfamiliar) brands (Dahlén & Lange, 2004). Thus:

P<sub>4</sub>: High levels of familiarity with the brand elements in the story will increase the likelihood of narrative transportation occurring.

### ***Cognitive load***

Processing narratives (especially narratives containing incongruence) requires cognitive resources. When consumers are under heavy cognitive load, they are less likely to be transported (e.g., Chang, 2009). Consumers may experience heavy cognitive load when dealing with multiple inputs at the same time, such as a large number of ads a website. Stories placed in this environment are unlikely to lead to narrative transportation. Thus:

P<sub>5</sub>: High cognitive load will decrease the likelihood that the attention given to the story will be sufficient to drive narrative transportation.

Narrative transportation can be an effective method for persuasion (e.g., Escalas, 2007). However, consumers may possess persuasion knowledge, or beliefs about the motives and tactics used by marketers to persuade consumers (Campbell & Kirmani, 2000; Friestad & Wright, 1994). This knowledge forms over time as consumers interact with salespeople and evaluate marketing messages. This is important because inferences made about a marketer's attempt at manipulation will affect perceptions of the brand and its message, leading to adverse outcomes (e.g., Boerman et al., 2017; Germelmann et al., 2020; Grigsby & Mellema, 2020; Wentzel et al., 2010).

Online brand storytelling may elicit persuasion knowledge due to how it is promoted. Social media content is less likely to produce narrative transportation if the consumer is informed that the content is advertising due to the influence of persuasion knowledge (Seo et al., 2018). Many brands publish their stories as sponsored or promoted posts on social media, often through celebrity endorsers, influencers, or other brand partners. The 'sponsored' label conveys that the message is an advertisement, which can make manipulative intent salient and cause consumers to draw on their persuasion knowledge (Boerman et al., 2017). Native advertising, another outlet for brand stories, can also elicit persuasion knowledge (Amazeen & Wojdyski, 2019; Grigsby & Mellema, 2020; Jing Wen et al., 2020). If a consumer draws upon persuasion knowledge, it will negatively impact the ability of the brand story to drive positive outcomes, whether or not narrative transportation occurs. Therefore:

P6a: Activation of persuasion knowledge will negatively affect the ability of narrative transportation to drive positive brand outcomes.

P6b: Activation of persuasion knowledge will negatively affect the ability of schema incongruity to drive positive brand outcomes in the absence of narrative transportation.

## Discussion

Storytelling has the potential to be an effective method of persuasive communication for brands. Most consumers today expect brands to tell stories, but few stick in their memory (Mortimer, 2015). Brand storytellers must find new ways to make an impression. Introducing elements to a brand story that are inconsistent with consumers' expectations, or schemas, is likely to grab the attention of consumers. This research develops a conceptual model and propositions that incorporate schema incongruity, narrative transportation, and moderating factors to explain the effectiveness of brand storytelling and guide brand storytellers toward favorable outcomes.

### *Theoretical implications*

This research offers significant contributions to marketing theory. The proposed relationships between story elements, incongruity, and narrative processing in the conceptual model (Figure 1) tie together disparate areas of research within brand communication – schema incongruity and narrative processing. Incongruity with schema draws attention and triggers cognitive processing in the mind of the story receiver (Lee & Schumann, 2004). Attentional focus is necessary for narrative transportation, which occurs through cognitive processing (Green & Brock, 2000). Linking these two communication concepts makes sense and represents a significant step in brand storytelling research.

Additionally, the notion of brand story schema is a worthwhile and prudent extension to brand communication research (e.g., Dahlén & Lange, 2004; Herskovitz & Crystal, 2010). Brand storytelling research is in a nascent stage, and marketers need to account for consumers' storytelling expectations moving forward. Otherwise, a significant portion of brand storytelling outcomes may go unexplained. Third, the idea of story schema is a new concept to storytelling research. Storytelling is ubiquitous in today's society, yet the author could find no research examining the encoding, storage, and retrieval of story-based schema. Consumers expect stories to follow a certain format, and this expectation comes from schema developed over a long period of time.

### *Managerial implications*

This research is driven by a desire to give marketing managers methods for improving brand storytelling effectiveness. Thus, a number of managerial contributions can be drawn from this paper. First, this research identifies the importance of incongruity in drawing attention to brand stories. Consumers are awash in marketing content today, and countering consumer expectations through the use of incongruity is an effective way for brands to make an impact.



Brand story schema incongruity can aid brand managers in accomplishing strategic goals. For example, the Anheuser-Busch water canning ad demonstrates that incongruity can be used to show the public a different side of the company, one aligned with consumer expectations of corporate responsibility. The Tesla customer story about car safety highlighted an unknown benefit of Tesla's vehicles that represents a major factor in consumer car buying decisions. Incongruity can also introduce new products to consumers (e.g., Subway breakfast sandwiches) and draw new potential customers to the company's products (e.g., Minnetonka Moccasins). Incongruency is a means for upending expectations, which brands often seek to do.

Additionally, this research breaks down the individual elements of a story and demonstrates how brand managers can manipulate each element to achieve incongruity. The characters, setting, and plot all offer opportunities to introduce incongruent elements. For example, a character that acts against the brand persona can appeal to new target consumers. The time and location for the story can signal when and where a brand's products are usually used. By changing one of these elements, brands can expand the use scenarios of its products. Marketers would be well-served in learning the elements involved in storytelling and how to construct a story to achieve specific ends. Examples of brand stories using incongruity are included to aid both understanding and application (see [Table 1](#) and [Appendix A](#)). In addition, this research offers specific recommendations for implementing schema incongruity into storytelling elements (below).

Lastly, the conceptual model incorporates factors which managers can control (i.e., level of incongruity of story elements), capitalize on (i.e., prior knowledge/brand familiarity) or mitigate (i.e., cognitive load and persuasion knowledge). Brand managers and

**Table 1.** Examples of incongruity with brand story elements.

| Story Element                   | Incongruence with Schema                                                                           | Example                                                                                                             |
|---------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Characters                      | Character portrayed in story does not match the usual persona associated with the brand            | Ariel laundry soap story encouraging dads to #ShareTheLoad                                                          |
| Setting Time                    | The time in which the story takes place is not the time the brand is normally used                 | Subway Breakfast ad                                                                                                 |
| Location                        | The location of the story is one where the brand is not expected                                   | Minnetonka Moccasins used on a backpacking adventure                                                                |
| Plot Goal                       | The goal sought by the character is one not previously associated with (or fulfilled by) the brand | Whirlpool Care Counts stories about increasing school attendance                                                    |
| Challenge/                      | Struggle                                                                                           | The obstacle that prevents the characters from achieving the goal is one not usually faced by the brand's customers |
| Maltesers                       | chocolates ad series featuring stories of the disabled; Anheuser-Busch immigrant origin story      |                                                                                                                     |
| Help/                           | Super Bowl ad Solution                                                                             |                                                                                                                     |
|                                 |                                                                                                    | The brand provides a solution for overcoming the challenge that had not been associated with the brand before       |
| Anheuser-Busch water canning ad | (response to storm emergencies), Tesla Safety First customer story                                 |                                                                                                                     |

Note: Sources for brand examples can be found in [Appendix A](#)

the agencies they work with have control over story elements. Targeting consumers with brand familiarity will enhance the likelihood of narrative transportation, leading to positive outcomes. Marketers can achieve a similar boost in narrative transportation by presenting brand stories to consumers during times of low cognitive load, which will allow them to devote more attention and focus to the brand story. Lastly, if brands can avoid eliciting consumers' persuasion knowledge during the storytelling process, the story will not be seen as manipulative. Based on extant research, persuasion knowledge is often triggered through cues in the story itself or by disclosing that the story is a paid ad. While promoting and sponsoring brand stories as online ads can increase reach, it may undermine the authenticity of the storyteller.

### ***Recommendations for implementation***

In order to introduce incongruence into brand storytelling, one or more of the storytelling elements outlined in [Figure 1](#) must be manipulated to be incongruent with consumer expectations. See [Table 1](#) for a summary of these elements and current examples of brands using this technique. Below is a short discussion of each major element.

#### ***Character incongruence***

The character in a story is one of the first elements people perceive. The main character of a brand story is often a typical customer of the brand or the easily recognizable and memorable brand persona – 'the articulated form of the brand's character and personality' (Herskovitz & Crystal, 2010, p. 21). In the case of a customer character, incongruence is accomplished by introducing a character that is unlike the typical customer of the brand. This could be part of a strategic move to pursue under-tapped consumer segments. One example is the Ariel laundry soap ad in India that encouraged dads to '#ShareTheLoad' around the house and help with the laundry ([Appendix A](#)).

The brand persona provides a consistent point of reference for consumers across brand assets and represents the brand's values to the world. A strategic deviation from an established brand persona would be an impactful form of incongruence that would make a strong impression. However, introducing incongruence directly with the brand persona is risky and would likely require a longer-term approach accompanied by a strategic change within the firm.

#### ***Setting: time incongruence***

The setting of a story (i.e., time and place) is crucial to establishing context. In brand storytelling, time can be considered in two ways: the time in which a consumer encounters a brand and its products, and the broader time period in which the brand exists in history. Introducing incongruence to the time of use shifts the context people use when thinking of the brand. A good example is the Subway Breakfast ad, which introduced customers to new morning hours and breakfast items ([Appendix A](#)). The ad features a disheveled character named Bruce who 'is not designed to operate at 7 AM.' One morning, Bruce stumbles into Subway 'at the right time.' The breakfast sub and coffee combo snaps Bruce out of his daze.

It is also possible to set a brand story in a time period not associated with the brand. This construal of time is more difficult to accomplish and comes with added costs such as

period staging and dress, and perhaps special effects. An example of this form of incongruence is the medieval knight ad campaign by Bud Light ([Appendix A](#)) that highlights the use of corn syrup in competitors' beer. The medieval setting draws viewers in and grabs their attention.

### ***Setting: location incongruence***

The location of a story is vital to framing the other story elements. Consumers expect to encounter brands in certain locations but not others, which makes location a prime target for incongruity. A story posted by Minnetonka Moccasins ([Appendix A](#)) details a hiking adventure undertaken with the brand's moccasins, including pictures taken at stops along the hike. Moccasins are usually sold for leisure use in the U.S., with a focus on style and comfort. Displaying them in a lounge or bedroom would be congruent with expectations. Taking them on a hike may cause consumers to reconsider the product's characteristics.

### ***Plot: goal incongruence***

Plot is the engine that drives the story. A plot contains various elements, but this research focuses on the goal, challenge, and solution. A character strives to achieve a goal (i.e., fulfill a want or need). For example, a mom tries to get her kids to school on time. In a brand story, the brand and its products are tied closely to the goal. To introduce incongruence, the storyteller needs to associate the brand with a goal not usually sought by the brand's customers (or not usually fulfilled by the brand). This could change the way people think about the brand and its place in their lives.

An example is the Care Counts campaign by Whirlpool to address student dropout rates ([Appendix A](#)). The video features interviews with people like 4<sup>th</sup> grader Vanessa, who says 'When I wake up in the morning and I find out I have no clean clothes, I usually end up just staying home.' Another student said that when his family was homeless, they had to spend their money on food and not clean clothes. Whirlpool installed washers and dryers in schools to allow students to do their laundry and attend class without shame. Whirlpool has always been associated with doing laundry, but not with a goal such as keeping kids in the classroom.

### ***Plot: challenge/struggle incongruence***

When a character pursues a goal, the storyteller introduces tension to the story by placing challenges, or obstacles, in front of the character that they must overcome to achieve the goal. For example, a mom tries to get her kids to school on time, but breakfast takes too long. In congruent stories, the challenge rings true for the brand's customers. In an incongruent story, the challenge is one not familiar to the brand's typical customers. An example is the Maltesers chocolate ad in the U.K. ([Appendix A](#)). The ad features a disabled actress describing a romantic encounter that was almost cut short by her disability.

### ***Plot: help/solution incongruence***

As the character pursues the goal and struggles to overcome challenges, help emerges in the form of a brand's product. The obstacles are overcome, and the character accomplishes the goal. The mom can now get her kids to school on time with the help of Kellogg's breakfast bars. In congruent stories, brands play to their known strengths and demonstrate how their products can help people accomplish their goals. In stories with an

incongruent solution, the audience is shown a new side of the brand. An example is the Anheuser-Busch water canning ad ([Appendix A](#)). Everyone is familiar with the AB brand, but few people know they ship cans of water to hurricane relief sites, where clean fresh water is scarce. Another example is the Tesla customer story about a severe car accident that left the driver unscathed. People do not usually associate Tesla with safety.

### **Future research**

The topic of incongruity in brand storytelling is rife with future research possibilities. First, with the help of technology, consumers can now be active participants or co-creators in brand storytelling (Lund et al., 2018; Singh & Sonnenburg, 2012). Consumers may naturally introduce incongruence into their stories, since their experiences with a brand will be diverse, unpredictable, and personal. Customer stories are unlikely to mimic the ways in which the brand portrays itself, and they will be seen as more authentic. Future research should examine the effectiveness of customer-introduced incongruity and how brands can harness it.

Second, the topic of strategic incongruity in storytelling can be further pursued. Tying storytelling elements and forms of incongruity to strategic marketing goals is the next logical step. For example, if a firm wanted to introduce a new product feature to an existing market to solve an emerging consumer problem, what would be the best way to highlight this feature using incongruity? How would this be different than the solution for introducing a new-to-the-world product? Answering these questions would require researchers to map the methods for achieving incongruence onto known strategy issues. Such an endeavor would be highly useful to marketers.

Third, while this research makes a strong case for the use of incongruity in storytelling, future research needs to empirically investigate the relationships proposed in the conceptual model. Experimental research exists on the use of incongruity in advertising (e.g., Dahlén & Lange, 2004; Halkias & Kokkinaki, 2013, 2014), however no such studies exist for brand storytelling. Specifically, experiments should examine the impact of incongruity when used in each storytelling element. It is likely that some elements are more effective agents of incongruity than others. Additionally, brand, product, and industry factors will impact the effectiveness of incongruity in storytelling. For example, it is unclear if technology brands would benefit from placing the story out of time with the technology featured in the story. Doing so may have unintended consequences such as the technology being perceived as dated by the consumer.

### **Disclosure statement**

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

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## Appendix A. Examples of Incongruity in Brand Storytelling

Anheuser-Busch immigrant origin story

'Born the Hard Way'

Source: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=7ZmlRtpzwos>

Anheuser-Busch water canning ad

'Stand By You'

Source: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=GNVw5f16GEM>

Ariel India laundry soap ad

'#ShareTheLoad'

Source: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8QDlv8kfwlM>

Bud Light medieval knights ad

'Special Delivery'

Source: [https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=LkHvj\\_KEHBk](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=LkHvj_KEHBk)

Maltesers chocolates ad series

'New Boyfriend'

Source: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=YgUqmKQ9Lrg>

'Theo's Dog'

Source: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=lyIEAlogarI>

Minnetonka moccasins

'Everyday Adventure Big Pine Creek'

Source: <https://www.minnetonkamoccasin.com/blog/everyday-adventure-big-pine-creek/>

Subway UK Ireland breakfast ad

'My Sub, My Way'

Source: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=dYrOJGQQqc0>

Tesla customer story

'Safety First'

Source: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=naxbzoME6V4>

Whirlpool program to install washers and dryers in schools to reduce absences

'Care Counts'

Source: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=oxbipSM8GmA>



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